



MCCARREN ADVISORY GROUP

BUSINESS ADVISEMENT GUIDE

The Owner-Independent Business Guide

Five levers that make a company run — and sell — without depending on you.

A field guide from

Shaun McCarren · Founder & Principal

mccarrenadvisory.com · Rockford, IL

If you disappeared for 30 days... what breaks?

Imagine you're unreachable for one month starting tomorrow — no calls, no texts, no "quick questions." Picture the business without you in it. What breaks first? Who's guessing? Which decisions simply wait for you to get back?

That thought experiment is the single most useful diagnostic I know. The honest answer tells you exactly how dependent your company is on **you** personally — and owner dependency is the biggest hidden discount on what your business is worth. A company that only runs when the founder is in the building isn't a company yet; it's a very demanding job you happen to own.

“Most advisors optimize the transaction. I make the business transferable in the first place — so it runs better now and is worth more whenever you're ready.”

SHAUN MCCARREN, MCCARREN ADVISORY GROUP

Here's the good news: reducing owner dependency isn't a mysterious art. It comes down to five levers. Pull them in order and the business gets calmer, more valuable, and far easier to hand off, sell, or simply step back from — on your timeline, not a crisis's.

Five levers that make a company run without you

1 Get the decisions out of your head

Map the decisions that currently route through you and hand each one a clear owner, a budget, and a boundary. If every judgment call needs your blessing, you are the bottleneck — by design.

2 Build a real #2 and a leadership bench

One capable second-in-command changes everything. Develop them deliberately: give real authority, let them make (and own) calls, and coach rather than rescue. Depth on the bench is what buyers and successors pay for.

3 Turn tribal knowledge into systems

The way you quote, hire, ship, and solve problems shouldn't live only in your memory. Documented processes and simple SOPs make quality repeatable and make you replaceable — in the best possible way.

4 Run the business by the numbers

A short set of KPIs and a steady operating cadence (a real weekly meeting, clear scoreboards) let the team steer without you reading every tea leaf. What gets measured gets managed — without you.

5 Find the small tweaks that add up

An outside set of eyes almost always spots the minor changes — a pricing adjustment, a workflow fix, a technology or ERP gap — that add meaningful revenue or cut real cost. Small levers, big compounding.

Why the order matters

Decision rights and a strong #2 come first because they create the capacity to build everything else. Try to document systems before anyone but you can run them, and the binder just gathers dust.

SCORE YOURSELF

The 30-Day Disappear Test

Check every statement that is true today — honestly, as the business actually runs, not as you hope it would. Each unchecked box is a place the company still depends on you.

DECISIONS & AUTHORITY

- ☐ Day-to-day decisions have **clear owners** who don't need to check with me.
- ☐ Spending up to a set limit is **approved without me**.

PEOPLE & LEADERSHIP

- ☐ There is a capable **#2** who can run operations in my absence.
- ☐ Key roles have a **backup** — no single point of failure but me.
- ☐ My team **solves problems** without waiting for my answer.

SYSTEMS & KNOWLEDGE

- ☐ Core processes are **documented**, not just in my head.
- ☐ A new manager could **learn the essentials** from our systems.
- ☐ Customer and vendor relationships **aren't solely mine**.

NUMBERS & RHYTHM

- ☐ We track a handful of **KPIs** the team actually uses.
- ☐ A **regular operating meeting** runs with or without me.

8-10 checked: strong — you own a business, not a job. **4-7:** real progress, clear gaps to close. **0-3:** the business depends on you far more than it needs to — and that's the most valuable thing to fix first.

You don't have to figure this out alone

I'm Shaun McCarren, and I'm a family-business owner myself — I've run a company, met a payroll, and lived the same highs and lows you do. I started McCarren Advisory because I've watched how easy it is to put off these conversations, and how much harder that makes things for the people you love and for the business you built.

Part succession planner, part hands-on advisor, I fill the gap that usually sits between your attorney and your accountant — the person who actually helps you build the plan and then execute it. I come from manufacturing, automation, and finance, so I fix what's really holding value back, then build the path to a confident transition.

Start with a confidential conversation

No pitch, no pressure — 30 minutes to understand your situation and tell you honestly if and how I can help. Most owners start with a low-cost Readiness Assessment: a walkthrough, a few management interviews, and a written risk map and roadmap you keep either way.

Email: preparedwith@mccarrenadvisory.com

Call or text: (779) 210-8351

Web: mccarrenadvisory.com

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